

Chapter 24 - Awkward

Everyone's gazes also moved with her and fell on Ning Fuyi's face.

Being hugged like this, Ning Fuyi unconsciously took two steps back. Looking up, she met the varied stares of the crowd, so she coughed a few times and pressed on the young girl's shoulders, trying to push her away.

However, after pushing once without success, she gave up and let her hands drop, awkwardly greeting the crowd: "Hi."

"Ning Fuyi! You..."

"Sister, where is this place? I was clearly captured by bad people, so why did I appear here?" The young girl interrupted Li Zhao'an's words, burrowing her entire body into Ning Fuyi's embrace with a frightened appearance.

"I know that Spirit Clan members have low status while cultivators are distinguished. We're used to being bullied in daily life, so getting beaten now isn't anything unusual. But I beg sister to save my life - don't let them eat me." The young girl's pretty face was covered with teardrops, like a delicate flower shedding tears, making all who heard and saw feel pity and affection.

Ning Fuyi watched her crying, the corners of her mouth twitching slightly, but she said nothing. However, Li Zhao'an behind her couldn't bear it anymore and nearly jumped up.

"Hey! What do you mean by that? With so many fellow disciples watching, I merely inquired about your identity and background. I didn't even raise my hand - when did I ever touch a finger to you!" Li Zhao'an angrily threw her braids back and pushed through the crowd to scold: "Besides, we're all proper disciples of an immortal sect. Who said anything about eating you!"

The young girl looked like she was about to be frightened to tears. She released her hands and hid behind Ning Fuyi, sobbing: "I'm just a small grass spirit who doesn't understand the immortal arts of you immortal masters. Perhaps this immortal master didn't hit me - maybe I'm just weak and fell by myself."

As she spoke, she rolled up her sleeves, intentionally or unintentionally revealing a section of fresh bruising, causing the crowd to gasp.

"Li Zhao'an, she's so young and her body is weak. Your cultivation is higher than hers and you're older - how could you strike with such force!" Liu Wenzhu couldn't stand seeing the weak being bullied most of all. She immediately protected the young girl behind her.

Except for Shaobing¹ and Miantiao², the people Li Zhao'an brought were mostly older disciples from the Southwest Courtyard. They had their own sense of right and wrong. Originally, they had only come to watch after hearing that Ning Fuyi had privately brought outsiders into Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, never intending to harm anyone. Now they couldn't hold back either and all spoke up.

"Junior sister, is this the person of unknown identity you mentioned? I see she's just a child. Just report to an elder or the sect leader - why make such a big fuss?" a tall male disciple said.

"Yes, and she's from the Spirit Clan. Spirit Clan members all have low magical power. We're one of the Six Great Sects after all - we should treat their clan kindly. If this matter spreads, how will people in the martial world view our sect?" another rather elderly female disciple chimed in.

"And injuring people is even more wrong." Yet another person spoke up.

Li Zhao'an had always been the center of attention like stars surrounding the moon. Now being blamed without reason, plus being unable to defend herself, made her so angry her hair nearly stood on end: "I really didn't hit her! Believe me!"

"And you! What nonsense are you spouting! Don't think you can gain others' pity just because of your lowly status. What we're discussing today is Ning Fuyi privately bringing people back to the sect. If you have a clear conscience, why were you hiding just now!" Li Zhao'an turned to scold the young girl.

"I, I..." The young girl's fan-like eyelashes trembled as she reached to pull at Ning Fuyi's sleeves, sobbing so hard she couldn't speak.

Ning Fuyi felt like she was both in the middle of the situation and outside of it. Only now did she interject: "Who said I privately brought people back to the mountain gate? Man'er is a survivor from Ruyan Tower that day. Because she was unconscious and we couldn't determine her background, we brought her back. Wenzhu and I had already reported this to Elder Yuanming early on. After he agreed, we settled her here. If you don't believe it, you can ask Elder Yuanming."

"No need, I'm already here." As soon as she finished speaking, someone walked in from outside. Without turning around, Ning Fuyi could tell who it was just from that swaggering shadow.

"What's all the noise about in broad daylight? I could hear it from up in the tree. Not cultivating or sleeping, but gathering together to play mahjong³?" Elder Yuanming yawned as he stopped beside Ning Fuyi. After seeing the sobbing young girl, he waved at her amiably.

"Oh, Zhao'an, your leg is fine now?" Elder Yuanming raised his bushy eyebrows and asked with concern.

It would have been better if he hadn't mentioned it. Once he did, Li Zhao'an remembered the day Elder Yuanming had carried her out of the fox den in such an embarrassing state. Her small face turned completely red: "Much, much better. Thank you, Elder."

"Elder Yuanming." The other disciples also respectfully greeted him.

Elder Yuanming nodded to them all, then flapped his wide sleeves like bird wings: "Alright, alright. I gave permission for this girl to be brought back. You all disperse now and go do whatever you're supposed to do. If you attract Elder Pingyao later, you'll get another good scolding."

"But..." Li Zhao'an wanted to say more, but after being glared at by Elder Yuanming, she didn't dare speak. She could only suppress her belly full of anger, bow, and leave.

The other disciples immediately scattered like birds and beasts. The previously crowded courtyard soon had only Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu left.

"Wenzhu, there's still one stone lion that hasn't been moved to Xuanliang Courtyard⁴." Elder Yuanming said with a smile. "All the strong men in the sect combined can't match your strength. I called several disciples but they couldn't move it. I'll have to trouble you again."

Hearing this, Liu Wenzhu looked at Ning Fuyi, then at Elder Yuanming, and immediately understood. She nodded, rolled up her sleeves to reveal her slender arms, and went to move the stone lion.

Only the three of them remained in the courtyard. Elder Yuanming gestured toward the guest room with a "please" motion. Ning Fuyi looked down at the young girl's wet eyes, said nothing, and walked into the guest room.

"What does the Elder want to say?" Ning Fuyi asked directly.

"Do you know this girl's identity?" Elder Yuanming put away his casual attitude and placed his palm on Man'er's shoulder, gently squeezing.

"Spirit Clan?" Ning Fuyi didn't know what he was getting at, so she answered casually.

"Spirit Clan members are found throughout the six realms, so that's not unusual. But because they're transformed from all things in heaven and earth, different origins create differences between ordinary and extraordinary ones. For example, that nine-tailed fox demon is ordinary - her abilities are just bewitching others, nothing precious. But if formed from immortal herbs, they have miraculous healing effects for cultivators. Ordinary immortal herbs can greatly increase cultivation, and if you encounter rare ones, they might even help achieve enlightenment directly."

"There are many greedy people in the world who pursue such Spirit Clan members frantically, competing to capture them. Some devour them on the spot, or keep them at home, drinking their fresh blood and cutting off their limbs. Even worse, some force dual cultivation⁵ with them to improve their cultivation."

Though spoken casually, these words made Ning Fuyi very uncomfortable. She glanced at the downcast Man'er and pretended not to know the truth: "So her true form is a precious immortal herb?"

Elder Yuanming neither confirmed nor denied, spinning the fan in his hand: "Yes, and she transformed not long ago. She has no ability to protect herself and can't even conceal the Spirit Clan scent on her body. So I consulted with Sect Leader Mei and received permission for her to stay at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate temporarily. When she grows up later, we'll send her back to her place of transformation - Heavenly Mountain."

Heavenly Mountain. Ning Fuyi's heartstrings moved. It seemed that today's Man'er was indeed Du Baishuang from her previous life.

However, though her personality was still the same as before, she had only just transformed after all. She posed no threat to Ning Fuyi, so she could just let her be.

"Remember what I said - I've cast a spell to mask the scent on your body. From now on, stay at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and never mention your identity to others." Elder Yuanming put on a face full of smiles as he spoke to Man'er.

Man'er seemed frightened by his deliberately kind appearance and hid behind Ning Fuyi, nodding.

Seeing Elder Yuanming smile as he stood up, Ning Fuyi asked suspiciously: "Since her identity mustn't be mentioned to others, why did the Elder tell this disciple about it?"

"Her mind isn't fully developed yet. In such a large Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, there needs to be someone who can look after her somewhat." Elder Yuanming sighed softly and patted Ning Fuyi's shoulder with his fan. "You're the young sect leader, the only bloodline of the former sect leader. This matter is most suitable for you to handle."

Ning Fuyi didn't speak. Whether in her previous life or this one, although Elder Yuanming seemed the most unreliable of the four great elders - constantly traveling and indulging in wine and pleasure, acting very whimsically - he was indeed the only elder in the sect besides Ning Changfeng who didn't think she was hopeless.

"Yes." Ning Fuyi agreed.

But in her heart, she had no intention of actually doing it. She could barely take care of herself - where would she find time to look after others? Besides, seeing how this girl had played Li Zhao'an just now, she probably wouldn't suffer any bullying.

"Then there's nothing more. It's past noon now, so I'll take my leave first." Elder Yuanming nodded with satisfaction, turned around, and his sleeves filled with wind, fluttering loudly.

"I'll also go back to cultivate." Ning Fuyi spoke up. She quietly pulled her sleeves from Man'er's hands, didn't look at her again, and followed Elder Yuanming out of Yinglai Pavilion.

Though the sun was fierce today, the wind was strong, making the leaves rustle loudly.

"Oh right, look at my brain." Elder Yuanming, who was about to mount his sword, suddenly remembered something and slapped his forehead. He jumped down from his sword that was glowing with green light and pulled out half a pitch-black stone from his sleeve, placing it in Ning Fuyi's hands.

"What is this?" Ning Fuyi weighed it in her hand.

"This is Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's Crimson Jade Sect Seal⁶. It's now split in two and given to the two sect leaders. I still have urgent matters to handle and can't personally deliver it to Divine Venerable Chu Ling, so help me make this trip." Elder Yuanming waved his hand carelessly. "Remember, this is the sect leader's only token. You must personally give it to Divine Venerable Chu Ling - don't hand it to anyone else."

"But..." Hearing it was for Chu Qingqiu, Ning Fuyi was about to refuse when Elder Yuanming suddenly jumped onto his sword and flew away like he was escaping.

Ning Fuyi held her hand up in mid-air, watching Elder Yuanming become a small dot on the horizon, then helplessly lowered her hand.

Sure enough, no one wanted to deal with Chu Qingqiu. She snorted softly.

She stared at the broken stone in her hand, weighing it for a long time, then finally sighed and resignedly turned around, heading toward Jingshan Palace.

This so-called Crimson Jade Sect Seal sounded impressive, but it was actually just a stone Ning Changfeng had picked up from the roadside. At that time, Ning Changfeng had returned from drinking tea at another sect and saw that they all had treasures symbolizing their sect leader position. He felt Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate should have one too, but unfortunately couldn't find any unique rare treasures. While pondering left and right, he was hit on the head by a stone that fell from the mountain. So he immediately picked up that stone, polished it round, and with a grand stroke, named it the Crimson Jade Sect Seal.

Jingshan Palace wasn't far away. Ning Fuyi soon stood before the palace gates. Before she could knock, the door creaked open.

After the door opened, no one appeared, but she felt something soft against her legs. Looking down, she saw the cat-sized little white tiger circling around her legs, nuzzling with its head.

"Bai Lin?" Ning Fuyi was somewhat surprised. She hadn't expected that while Chu Qingqiu was at odds with her, Chu Qingqiu's spirit beast was so friendly to her.

Logically, contracted spirit beasts should be of one mind with their masters, sharing likes and dislikes.

Ning Fuyi felt flattered and reached out her hand. The white tiger actively put its head into her palm.

Qiu Yi had gone somewhere, and Chu Qingqiu didn't like using servants, so the palace was empty. Ning Fuyi went straight in with the white tiger and climbed up to the pavilion where Chu Qingqiu lived.

But just as she walked up the steps, she saw white robes flutter past. Someone was walking quickly while a slightly angry voice came from inside to outside: "Qiu Yi, I instructed you to change its water. Why has it withered like this after only a few days?"

Ning Fuyi's heartstrings jumped. The person opposite also sensed something wrong, so the two faced each other and simultaneously stopped.

Ning Fuyi's gaze first focused on Chu Qingqiu's instantly changing expression, then slowly moved down to see what she was holding in her hands.

Inserted in a vase was a large bunch of wilted white chrysanthemums.

Author's Notes:

Chu Qingqiu: Hehe, this venerable's old face shall be lost here today.

Footnotes:

1. **Shaobing (烧饼)** - Literally "baked cake," appears to be a nickname for a disciple
 2. **Miantiao (面条)** - Literally "noodles," appears to be another disciple's nickname
 3. **Mahjong (马吊)** - An ancient Chinese tile game, predecessor to modern mahjong
 4. **Xuanliang Courtyard (悬梁苑)** - Name of a courtyard within the sect
 5. **Dual cultivation (双修)** - A cultivation practice involving intimate spiritual connection between partners
 6. **Crimson Jade Sect Seal (赤玉门玺)** - The official seal representing the sect leader's authority
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Author's Notes: This chapter develops the awkward situation with Man'er (Du Baishuang) while setting up the revelation of Chu Qingqiu's secret feelings. The discovery that Chu Qingqiu has been keeping the chrysanthemums Ning Fuyi gave her creates a deliciously embarrassing moment that promises to shift their relationship dynamics.